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Tanzania youth and social media: perceptions, experiences and implications for human rights violations

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ABSTRACT

Social media (SM) use has surged dramatically over the past few decades due to widespread access to electronic devices and the internet. Although SM platforms provide various benefits, there are clear patterns of young people's misuse, leading to violations of human rights. The article builds on earlier global studies by qualitatively analysing how university students perceive and experience SM use in promoting human rights (HR) violations. The data were collected through Focus Group Discussion (FGD) and face-to-face Key In-depth Interview (KII) techniques and analysed thematically through NVivo 12 software. The findings revealed a greater degree of awareness about SM and HRs. There were also instances of SM abuse motivated by peer pressure, financial gain, self-political interests, and relational conflicts. These contributed to abuses of children's, women's, and youth rights. It recommends that stakeholders teach youth about essential societal values and challenges associated with ICT use to avoid SM misuse.

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Background

The global spread in access to and social media (SM) usage in recent years has exposed many people to various risks and opportunities due to its capacity for quick information transfer (Boulianne, 2015; Cohen et al., 2014; Elsaesser et al., 2021; Mahamid & Berte, 2019; Nesi, 2020; Victor et al., 2024). Exposing people's privacy, sending hate speech and inflammatory messages, and posting nonsensical pictures, videos and audio clips are bullying are some of the human rights (HRs) violations expressed facilitated by SM (Abaido, 2020; Beausoleil, 2019; Buhmann & Olivera, 2020; Chenzi, 2021). Youth who are early adopters of information and communication technology (ICT) gadgets like phones and computers are reported to form the main users of Social Media Networks (SMNs) forums such as Facebook, Twitter, WhatsApp, Myspace, and Instagram more than adults (Harpin et al., 2016).

Indeed, the association between youth active use of SM and the problematic and unintended consequences of SM has captured the attention of scholars in the global

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north and global south. In global north countries like Italy, Finland, Germany, and the United States, where technological infrastructure is robust, SM has caused harm to youths by making them victims of harmful online content, cyberbullying, and online hatred (Biernesser et al., 2020; Micheli, 2016; Oksanen et al., 2014; Savolainen et al., 2020; Ybarra & Mitchell, 2008).

In low- and middle-income nations, SM usage has impacted youth, creating opportunities and threats (Livingstone et al., 2017). In India, Tripathi (2017) found that many youths actively engaged in SM have been victimized through street violence, which has turned into cybercrime and cyberbullying. According to Spyer (2018), youth in Brazil have been significantly affected by SM addiction, which has caused some of them to become inactive and materialistic, developing their criminal behaviour. Sub-Saharan Africa, one of the world's least developing regions, is not immune to human rights breaches caused by SM (Domatob & Domatob, 2011). Research conducted in Zimbabwe showed that the irresponsible use of SM by some persons inside and outside the campaign circles promoted human rights crimes (Mugari & Cheng, 2020). The usage of SM has drawn attention to the need to create a legal framework that will guarantee the protection of the right to information and freedom of speech under the constitution while also controlling the dissemination of hate speech and misleading information (Gawu & Mensah, 2022).

Tanzania has ratified various international and regional human rights instruments, such as the United Nations Declarations of Human Rights and the African Charter on Human Rights (Osler & Skarra, 2025; UNGA, 1949). The instruments, among other things, stress an individual's right to be free from arbitrary interference with his privacy, family, home, or correspondence, as well as attacks on his honour and reputation. The rights are explicitly specified in the country's constitutions and various legal frameworks and institutions (LHRC, 2024; URT, 2018). Likewise, Tanzania formulated multiple policies and legal frameworks to ensure the proper use of SM (URT, 2007, 2016). For instance, Pfeiffer et al. (2014) demonstrated improved reproductive health status of adolescents in the Dar es Salaam and Mtwara regions due to relevant and timely information through Facebook. Ikachoi (2017) found that while Facebook and WhatsApp improved students' communication skills, the same SM platforms also encouraged cyberbullying, which is linked to human rights violations among Tanzanian undergraduate students. The studies show that, despite international efforts and national human rights protection struggles and strategies implemented since its political independence (Fumbo, 2015; Kabudi, 1991; Kirby, 2015; Mwalusanya, 1995), the dynamics of technology manifested by the use of SM are likely impedes the progress that has been established.

Although numerous studies have been conducted around the world to investigate the link between SM misuse and human rights violations (Biernesser et al., 2020; Chetty & Alathur, 2018; Common, 2023; Cross, 2021; Manyerere, 2021b; Mihr, 2017), additional research is critical to investigate SM use among youths in promotion of human rights violations in the global south. Indeed, further research is required because earlier studies have indicated an increasing pattern in youth in the Global South's access to and use of social media, which has been connected to some negative effects on youths and other groups (Morah & Duru, 2018; Ngwainmbi, 2023). In the context of Tanzania, the detrimental implications of SM use among students at various levels, including multiple adverse effects on their health, learning, and academic results, cannot be overemphasized (Makundi & Osaki, 2022; Mbwele,

2022; Michael, 2023; Mvungi & Otieno, 2024). As a result, such SM misuse has implicated youths in the promotion of human rights violations, which, in turn, impede their positive development initiatives. It is under this premise that researching youth using Tanzanian undergraduate students as a case study contributes to determining the scope of the problem, allowing for better approaches to address human rights violations promoted by SM in the developing global south. Therefore, this article investigates Tanzanian youth perceptions, experiences of SM usage and its implication on human rights violations using undergraduate students in selected universities in the country. The article has three specific objectives: first, it examines youth perceptions of SM and HRs; second, it examines youth motivations for SM use; and third, it explores youth experiences of HR violations through SM.

Literature review

Understanding social media and human rights

The concept of social media can be defined as ‘web-based services that allow individuals, communities and organizations to collaborate, connect, interact and build community by enabling them to create, co-create, modify, share and engage with user-generated content that is easily accessible’ (McCay-Peet & Quan-Haase, 2016). Mayfield (2008) describes SM as ‘a group of emerging online media with several characteristics: participation, openness, conversation, community, and connectedness.’ In the context of this study, it will refer to all youth-preferred and commonly used online networks used to connect among themselves and share information with various groups but potentially cause violation of human rights if misused.

The concept of human rights lends to various explanations, and there is no universally accepted definition of human rights. Domatob (1989) insists on this by pointing out that there are many definitions of human rights, as there are several authors on the subject. However, this study adopted (Domatob & Domatob, 2011) understanding of human rights that generally refer to respect, dignity, and integrity people enjoy because they are humans. According to Domatob and Domatob (2011), key essential words that explain human rights are life, quality, liberty, the pursuit of happiness, and the right to privacy. The current article focused on a variety of liberties, including the right to respect vulnerable groups in society, such as youths and children, people with disabilities, as well as women, who often become the victims of SM content (Dolinsky & Helbig, 2015; Mossie & Wang, 2020).

Youth motivations for social media use and experiences

Studies on motives to use SM have pointed out several factors influencing youths to engage in SM. Kalam et al. (2023) indicated that entertainment (such as watching movies and listening to music) was their primary motivator, notwithstanding SM’s positive impact on academic performance. According to Sanmamed et al. (2017), entertainment is one of the key motivations; other motives include information searching, interpersonal utility, and efficiency of the SM in attaining their various goals. Dunas and Vartanov (2020) maintain that the use of SM among youth in Russia is primarily associated with the need for socialization and achieving

their full potential. Yet, factors such as recreational, informative, and fulfilling various instrumental needs through internet usage also play an essential role. Therefore, entertainment is one of the key reasons youths use SM, and it comes with several other rewards, such as increased engagement with people and more opportunities to encourage their positive growth.

Some literature also shows that peer pressure significantly influences youth to engage in and select SM (Nouh et al., 2014; Pinheiro et al., 2014; Sherman et al., 2018; Trivedi et al., 2022). For instance, peer affiliation manifested in Fear of Missing Out (FoMO) is expressed particularly in situations where youth believe SM to be an important means to access whatever they consider to have missed, excluded, or experienced by colleagues (Parent, 2023). Regarding the primary SM platforms used by Turkish undergraduate youth in Turkey, Kircaburun et al. (2020) observed that students mostly used Instagram, a platform viewed by youth as having a favourable association with meeting new people and delivering many benefits through contact. The benefits include giving students more opportunities to refresh their minds and enhancing their learning potential through effective academic knowledge exchange. Despite a variety of good motives for preference and better use of SM, youth have concerns about its adverse effects, such as time consumption, addiction to excessive reliance, and online bullying (Sharma et al., 2016).

Youth perceptions of social media and human rights violations

Literature indicates a strong connection between recognizing SM's role and ensuring HRs protection. Previous empirical studies have demonstrated that individuals' perceptions of SM have an immense effect on its use, contributing to the increase in the likelihood of the protection or violation of the rights of others (Boddy & Dominelli, 2017; Common, 2020; Schivinski & Dabrowski, 2016). Recognizing the risks associated with SM abuse, nations part of the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) stress the importance of legal frameworks to uphold individuals' rights, including protection against hateful speech and threats from various sources that prioritize the interests of offenders over those of marginalized groups (Nave & Lane, 2023). Similarly, individual responsibility to safeguard better use of SM, such as online privacy, has been emphasized by past studies (Hoofnagle et al., 2010; Tsay-Vogel et al., 2018). Self-control is one of the essential issues in preventing the sharing or circulation of undesirable or unethical comments or pictures that may offend people (Marwick et al., 2017).

Given the short- and long-term effects on individual positive growth, various initiatives are required to safeguard underprivileged groups such as children against the negative impacts of SM. Cyberbullying is one of the key online negative impacts likely to face children when they neither have accessibility to appropriate guidance from adults, parents, teachers, and other careers nor benefit from policy, legislative, and regulatory mechanisms (Livingstone & Bulger, 2014; Livingstone & Third, 2017). Previous research has indicated that youth victimization has far-reaching impacts on depression, anxiety, low self-worth, and lowliness in comparison with non-victimized youth (Biggs et al., 2010). A past study by Abu-

Shanab and Al-Tarawneh (2013) examined the empirical benefits and drawbacks of SM among young Jordanians and found that the most significant perceived drawback was the extreme addiction that comes with Facebook use.

Theoretical framework

This study subscribes to Social Aspects Theory (SAT) to explain the social influence that impacts an individual behaviour. The theory was initially developed by Kelman (1958) to explain the social influence that occurs whenever a person changes his behaviour due to induction by another person or group. Later, in the digital age, where SM was widely used, the theory was contextualized by other scholars, such as Cheung and Lee (2010), to explain how decisions are made in technology use. The theory advocates that social actions in online social networks are influenced by three main factors, namely compliance (subjective norm), identification (social identity) and internalization (group norm). Compliance in the use of SM happens when an individual accepts the influence of another person or group to obtain a favourable reaction from the other while earning a specific reward, acceptance, or avoiding a particular punishment controlled by the other. Identification happens when an individual accepts the influence of another person or group to establish or maintain a fulfilling, self-defining relationship with each other. By accepting influence, the person can see himself as similar to others. Internalization occurs when a person accepts influence to maintain the resemblance of his actions and beliefs with his value system. In the context of this study, this theory helps explain how human rights violations can be enabled by SM. Misuse may occur when youths aspire to identify with their social circle or the rest of society. For example, youths may misuse SM by spreading fake stories and speculations or embarrassing video clips and photographs that harm people's images and reputations and violate their rights in exchange for certain rewards such as recognition from peers, popularity, and socio-economic benefits such as money. Given the variety of ways viewers obtain SM content, the theory explains how different factors can lead youths to misuse SM and commit HR violations. As a result, this paper used the SAT to investigate undergraduate students' perceptions and experiences with SM use and HRs violations in Tanzania. In this way, the theory helps to understand how youths employ different forms of SM and how it affects human rights.

Methodology

Study area

The selected study area includes private and public universities in the Dar es Salaam, Morogoro, and Iringa regions. Six universities, two from each region (labelled as A1, A2, B1, B2, C1, C2), were purposely chosen from the various areas to represent a variety of characteristics, including chances to have admitted students from different regions of the country, the diversity of courses taught, as well as ownership status such as being private and public owned.

Research approach and sampling design

A qualitative approach was used to collect and analyse data. The approach was used because it offers a relevant way to gather and analyse data. It relies on how people understand things and give meanings based on the premise that knowledge is socially constructed (Creswell, 2011) The non-probability sampling design was used to collect data using snowball and purposive techniques. The snowball sampling technique facilitated access to students who were familiar with each other and interested in SM as potential interviewees. The purposive technique was used to identify Focus Group Discussion (FGD) members from all relevant categories of diversities. The categories include participant sex, year of study, and degree programmes.

Data collection techniques

Focus group discussion (FGD) and face-to-face interview (Key In-depth Interview-KII) were the data techniques employed to collect data. A total of eight (8) participants engaged in the research as interviewees. At least one (1) student from each university participated in the interview. A total of six (6) FGDs were conducted, one from each university consisting of at least five (5) to seven (7) members each, making thirty-nine (39) participants as indicated in Table 1. The researcher recorded the audio verbatim during the fieldwork exercise and later translated it into English, ready for thematic analysis through NVivo 12 software.

Data analysis

The collected data were analysed thematically in six stages, as Braun and Clarke (2006) explained, including familiarization with the data, generating initial codes, identifying themes, reviewing the topics, defining and naming the themes, and report preparation. Computer analysis software (NVivo 12) facilitated categorizing keywords and concepts into their specific nodes.

Ethical consideration

Ethical clearance was obtained to conduct the study. Before interviews and FGDs, respondents were informed about the study's aim, and their consent was obtained to admit voluntary participation. Codes were used to ensure that the potential readers of the research work did not identify study participants.

Table 1. Research participants.

Methods	Dar es Salaam		Morogoro		Iringa	
	A1	A2	B1	B2	C1	C2
KII	1	2	1	2	1	1
FGD	7	7	6	7	7	5

Findings

Youth perceptions of social media and human rights

This part comprises two main subthemes: youth perceptions of SM and human rights

Youth perceptions of social media

Youths expressed various perspectives regarding SM. Participants had a clear understanding and positive perception of SM in society. They explained what SM mean and how they are utilized to accomplish multiple goals. The following statements, during FGDs, indicate the way young people understood and had a positive perception of SM:

SM platforms enable people to communicate for various goals, like sharing ideas and chatting. Individuals can interact through SM platforms, including Facebook, Twitter, and WhatsApp. (FGD C2 R4)

I believe that SM is one of the communication means that assist people in getting information, interacting, and getting news about various events that happen either in the place where they are or outside the area around the world. (FGD A1 R1)

The statements above demonstrate an outstanding youth awareness of SM and its beneficial effect on humanity. As university students, participants had a high level of knowledge and possibly access to day-to-day SMU. Therefore, the results were unsurprising. Interviewees' comments verified the FGD's statements with definitions and listed multiple frequently utilized SM platforms as follows:

When we talk about SM, it's like the use of Facebook, WhatsApp, Instagram, and other social networks that people use to connect among themselves for multiple purposes. (KII C2 R4)

Participants' ability to provide instances of SM platforms while clarifying why SMs are important demonstrates their understanding.

However, while the majority of participants explained the essential characteristics of SM definition, some youth confused SM with other conventional media as they associated SM with print media, as illustrated below:

I understand SM as a tool or method for ensuring that information moves from one location to another. The information may be passed from one person to another or from one person to the public. That tool can offer either digital (SM) or natural (traditional) options. I understand that digital media can include platforms such as Facebook, Instagram, and others. However, this natural one can include books, printed versions of publications, and others. (FDG A2 R2)

The mentioning of traditional media as part of SM shows some misunderstanding of what exactly SM entails. Such misunderstanding may be attributed to a lack of access to SM targets or youths' socio-economic backgrounds with no adequate information regarding SM.

Youth perceptions of human rights

The study indicated that youth had an extensive understanding of human rights. Reasonable explications were provided for the HR concept as demonstrated below:

Human rights, as the name stands, refers to privileges that every person has to enjoy by being a human being; these are rights that responsible authorities should safeguard, and if not given or tempered, a person can go to court to file charges on the authority. (KII C2 R5)

Such a broad understanding of the concept of HRs implies the possibility of improved SM utilization and HR protection. FGD participants indicated a similar understanding of HRs, as follows:

Human rights include the right to life, which is the most crucial right. Every person has the right to live. Also, the right to worship. However, under the right to life, if any person does not have the right to live or is threatened with something, he has the right to report it to the relevant authorities because the right to life is significant. (FDG A2 R3)

Everyone has the right to protection, but children in particular. Children have the right to be protected from any challenges that can interfere with their other rights, like the right to life. That needs to be given or guaranteed by the parents or adults, and everyone in the community has the right to protection whenever they feel their safety is compromised. (FDG C1 R7)

The above statements demonstrated that youth had a strong awareness of human rights. Given their educational level, it is reasonable to predict that some students learnt about human rights in classes and through different experiences besides educational institutions.

Youth motivation behind social media usage

Four main motivations were found to influence youth to use SM, which were associated with HR violations. These include quick financial gains, promoting their status and gaining popularity, advancing political interests and relationship conflicts.

Quick financial gains

Aspiration to quickly accrue money from multiple SM viewers and account subscribers made youth use various strategies to attract viewers to their SM accounts. The following statement from FGD shows the extent to which youth have been hassling to increase followers for personal financial gains:

I believe the fundamental motivation is to meet financial needs. For example, when it comes to viewers, certain SM platforms explicitly mention that a person who has attained a particular number of viewers would be able to earn a certain amount of money (paid by the SM owners). As a result, one may consider having more viewers to increase income! To attract more people, disclose information about another individual or rely on fake news to gain more views and money. (FDG A2 R4)

The opportunities afforded by various SM platforms have influenced certain youths to use them for selfish benefit and violate other people's rights. It implies that the failure of SM account holders to employ safe methods to capitalize on SM contributes to harming others.

Peer pressure

The influence of peer pressure was found to significantly influence youth to attract more viewers and followers by posting pictures and video clips without considering the

negative impact on others, which has been a prevalent phenomenon. One FGD member explained how exactly a situation damaged the dignity and invaded other people's privacy:

Human rights breaches stemmed from friends' influence on SM usage in several ways. I use Facebook, for example, just like my friends do. People from all over the world like the photos we share. Regardless of the impact on the person who posted the image, if I share it and receive a lot of likes, I may convince my colleague to follow suit in the expectation of getting an equal number of likes. In this sense, violating the rights of others may happen. (FGD A2 R3)

The statement implies that HRs are sometimes violated due to seeking status on SM sites. As previously pointed out, a more significant number of viewers make youths feel valued more and have a higher status among their peers, even if the photos display private matters of others. Indeed, some youths seem to feel they have higher-profile roles when they have more likes than their peers. Thus, at the expense of other people's rights, they become addicted to socializing with SM viewers' likes to disregard other people's rights to privacy.

Political interests

Political interests have been associated with undesirable SM use by some youths, primarily involving politicians and their followers. In this manner, youths turned into propagating agents of politicians' priorities and self-interests. Participants, for example, stated that some youths use SM platforms to attack political opponents. This fact happens through posting photos, video clips, and foul remarks, assisted by SM. Thus, findings suggest that SM could be used to promote violations of human rights for personal gains in politics while hurting others. The below extract from one of the FGDs substantiates further:

I believe that interpersonal competition is a primary motivation for HR infractions. For example, a politician who does not respect another could use SM to bring down or destroy another politician. Politicians frequently utilise SM to undermine one another in public. (FGD C1 R3)

The statement implies that through the use of SM, competitors' rights are likely to be interfered with when personal political motives prevail. Abusive language and sending photos infringe on other people's rights to dignity and respect. As a result, the reputations of individuals get ruined.

Relationship conflicts

The findings further showed that conflicts over relationships among youth are among the primary drivers of SM misuse, leading to human rights violations. Some young people use SM for post-break-up revenge towards their ex-partners. It was stated that this usually happens when a partner fails to admit that the relationship that s/he wants to sustain is over. The revenge is generally expressed through exposing the ex-partner's pictures and video clips that violate human rights. The following comment from one of the interviewees explains the way SM is used to accelerate relationship conflicts that lead to HR violations:

I can discuss the subject of people in relationships. Sometimes, partners misunderstand, and the woman decides to move on to another man. Thus, a guy is left with disappointment and

might seek revenge by posting ill about the woman, that she has terrible behaviour and is a prostitute, which generates significant doubts for the new man about the woman, and that SM creates an unfavourable stance of the man to the woman, which might harm the woman's future. (KII 3 A2 R3)

The above scenario from an interview corresponds to another view stated in a different FGD, as follows:

The other reason people violate other people's rights is retaliation because ex-partners may be angry to be left alone (break a relationship) after a long period, such as three years. Then you leave a partner without any reasonable justification! The partner that is left will get revenge! Because I have your photos, and you will face the consequences! (A laughter). (FGD C1 R4)

The above remark implies that SM can be used to facilitate revenge, such as in an unsatisfactory break-up relationship. The consequence is much more serious if the spiteful has photos or video footage of the former partner that can be used to carry out the desired harm.

This part focuses on exploring human rights victimization that various groups of people face as a result of SM misuse as experienced by youth. It was found that youth, women and children were the primary victims associated with SM misuse. Youth had mixed perceptions regarding how the rights of the mentioned groups were violated through SM. Posting nude pictures and video clips and sending inflammatory and aggressive statements are some of the manifestations of human rights violations. It was further revealed that youth comprised the most dominating cohorts of both perpetrators and victims of HR violations due to their active SM use. The following statements from the FGD and interview demonstrate the extent to which youth cohorts were more involved as facilitators and victims of human rights violations:

I believe that the youth group is more likely to be affected by SM because the majority of SM active users and participants are young people. Because you may find that children are not yet exposed to and comprehended using SM, and old and adults are so busy with their duties and stuff like that. (FDG B2 R7)

I believe that the young population is the most likely to violate human rights through the use of SM because it is possible that someone can earn money through SM owing to the large number of viewers on his page. As a result, someone may even generate bogus tales to gain more viewers and earn money. (KII C2 R2)

The findings imply that active involvement by youth in utilizing SM increases the likelihood of being a perpetrator or victim of HR violations. Participants mentioned stories which have been created or spread by youth, including speculations about someone doing something wrong in society, posting embarrassing video clips exposing child harassment that need protection and spreading private photographs and pictures that harm people's images and reputations. As such, this shows how youth cohorts have been misusing SM. In another FGD, one respondent commented on the degree of the youth cohort young group's addiction to SM:

There's something called Fear of Missing Out (FoMO). That is generally known among many young people. FoMO occurs when a person loses his smartphone, not because it will hurt him

but because he can no longer communicate. No, since he has lost a gadget that allows him to access SM at any moment. (FDG B2 R4)

The statement demonstrates that the FoMO is SM addiction that is likely to lead to youth becoming obsessed with smartphones, which may promote HR violations. The FoMO may allow youth to spend more time surfing various SM platforms that promote abusive languages, exposing them to and facilitating the posting of nude pictures to colleagues or multiple groups. Related to the above, another stated negative impact that youths confront with SM use is the failure to attend to significant matters such as studies and social issues. Indeed, FoMO also may accelerate youth irresponsible and anti-social behaviours such as stealing and engaging in sexual behaviour. These behaviours, in turn, infringe on youth rights to positive self-development in various aspects.

In addition, the findings revealed that women have also been victims of SM, with their rights being violated in a variety of ways. The following statements outline the opinions of participants regarding how the rights of women have been infringed through the use of SM:

Yeah, my view is that the group most likely to be the victim of HR violations is women because women are regarded as inferior in everything. Still, when it comes to SM use, such as Facebook, YouTube, and Twitter, you may notice that the group that is demoralised and dresses poorly is a woman, and thus, women become the victims of HR violations. (FGD A2 R3)

Women are the primary target of HR violations. For instance, when a relationship breaks, a man might post private pictures, and thus, the woman ends up being humiliated, and this puts a woman at a better stance of their HR being violated. (FGD C1 R2)

The above statements show that the low status that certain community members ascribe to women significantly contributes towards cohort victimization. For instance, such behaviour of sending ex-partners private pictures might contribute towards developing and facilitating domestic violence through blackmailing strategies. In the context of developing countries such as Tanzania, where a significant population of women are illiterate and under men's control, women may be threatened easily to abide by men's wishes even if that degrades their dignity and rights. Indeed, pictures can be used to threaten women not to leave their partners. The findings suggest that social and cultural norms that degrade women as inferior contribute to women's rights violations.

Besides women, some participants had different perspectives, claiming that children are the primary victims. The following extract from one of the interviewees substantiates:

Youths suffer countless harassment and are documented, and once they are adults and see what happened to them in their childhood, it impacts them a lot and even us youths too. (KIL C2 R9)

Adults such as siblings, guardians, and teachers are responsible for protecting children's rights. As a result, neglecting to support children in safeguarding their rights raises the likelihood that people who misuse SM will ultimately victimize the rights of children for their own advantage.

When participants were asked about incidents of victimization engaging them or experienced by the ones they knew, the following testimony was given as evidence:

There are numerous human rights violations in the country. People occasionally hack into other people's accounts. Furthermore, there is inappropriate uploading of persons and exposing other people's secrecy and private concerns that are not supposed to be exposed to others or dehumanising others. (FGD C1 R4)

SM violates human rights by publishing nude photographs or using abusive or immoral words during a conversation. Considering that everyone utilises SM and is not restricted to children or adults, one could learn issues that are not proper based on their culture, so SM might breach HRs in such a way. (FGD A1 R1)

The above excerpt demonstrates that, like other groups, youngsters are also victims of SM use. This claim shows that any group will likely be affected because various people with diverse social interests use SM.

Discussion

The article investigated Tanzanian youth perceptions and experiences of SM usage and its implications for human rights violations. The findings showed that youth have a significantly better understanding and perception of SM and HRs. Youths are active SM users compared to other age groups, but their liveliness is associated with positive and negative consequences on HR. Higher education levels among youth greatly impacted how they understood and perceived SM and HRs. Such findings were predictable given the education level of the participants – undergraduate students at universities. Youth with internet-connected phones are likelier to engage in SMNs, including WhatsApp, Instagram, Facebook, and Twitter. Previous studies (Bal & Bicen, 2017; Sterling et al., 2017) revealed connections between university students' usage of and availability of SM and how it helps them in their studies, which is an important and common phenomenon in the exchange of information. Indeed, some participants' positive perceptions of SM suggest that youths use it more effectively to support their diverse socioeconomic endeavours. In this sense, the study has demonstrated that SM offers youths several advantages that enable them to achieve many objectives. In this context, the research has shown that SM provides numerous advantages for youths, which subsequently assist them in reaching various objectives. Our findings on the benefits of SM for youths align with earlier studies showing an association between SM and youth mental health and wellbeing (Addae, 2020; Buijs et al., 2016), access to opportunities for positive influence, self-expression, and social support (Popat & Tarrant, 2023; Vaingankar et al., 2022) and an improvement in standard of living (Fukuyama, 1995; Hajdu et al., 2011; Manyerere, 2021a; Putnam, 1993, 1995). Therefore, the current findings somewhat align with the above studies by showing how accessibility to and regular use of SM as valuable platforms for interaction and sharing of knowledge contribute to their improved understanding and perception of SM concepts and HRs.

Despite participants' improved awareness and perceptions of SM and HRs, as well as positive SM usage, our findings also revealed negative experiences with using SM, as evidenced by HR's violations of youth, women, and children. The posting of humiliating videos and pictures on SM platforms that expose people's privacy and express inflammatory remarks were negative impacts of SM misuse. Several factors can explain why the groups mentioned above become SM victims. These include the fact that youth were

identified as active SM users. So they had an increasing chance of being either perpetrators or victims. This view is closely linked to a previous study by Roberts and David (2019), which found that FoMO is positively associated with the intensity of SM use amongst college students at US colleges. Women's positions within society, particularly in the global south, are limited by established traditional and customary practices (Bawa, 2012; LeRoux-Rutledge & LeRoux-Rutledge, 2020). This practice was found to contribute to women's rights being violated by SM without their voices being heard. Furthermore, it was found that children's rights were easily violated due to their inability to defend themselves, and they were expected to be protected by adults such as parents, teachers, and siblings. Although some findings regarding SM misuse were unexpected, considering the participants' level of education and internet penetration and best practices in SM usage in both rural and urban areas of Tanzania (Manyerere, 2021a; Mchiro et al., 2024; Sedoyeka, 2016) they were not entirely surprising because some previous studies (Abaido, 2020; Bennett et al., 2011; Deans & Bhogal, 2019; Patton et al., 2013) had reported related findings that SM also has a damaging effect on youth of various socio-economic and educational background.

Understanding the motives and interests of university students in using SM was critical since it may help uncover underlying issues influencing youth behaviour. The study findings demonstrated that youth SM use's key motivations associated with human rights violations were income gains, peer pressure, political interests, and partner relationship conflicts. Studies demonstrate that several SM platforms, such as YouTube, reimburse account holders upon attaining a particular number of viewers and subscribers (Han, 2020; Wisankosol, 2021). According to the SAT, an individual can be inspired to perform a particular activity due to external influence from another person to expect a certain reward, identify with others, and be a member of a specific community (Cheung & Lee, 2010). Therefore, the present findings are in line with the theory and also corroborate studies regarding SM content creators, such as youth and their interests and motivations to earn money (Holmbom, 2015; Kopf, 2020) or blackmailing others to succeed in love proposals (Addadzi-Koom, 2021). Peer pressure among youth played a significant role in directing fellows to engage in harmful behaviours that violate HRs. Topics trending on SM significantly impact youth life in both developing and developed countries (Chung et al., 2021; Rice & Barman-Adhikari, 2014). In connection with the current study findings, another study concluded that people are influenced by their desire to gain affection and prestige in social networks since it improves their likelihood of survival (Anderson et al., 2015). With Tanzania's expanding creative industry, where most young people enjoy modern music like Bongo Flavour and the arts (Kitomari, 2022; Spemba, 2017), many are drawn to follow trends and copy certain popular artists without considering the negative impacts of SM.

SM is an effective channel for passing information from politicians to their citizens and vice versa. However, the present study has demonstrated that there are adverse effects of SM on politics where they have brought HR violations. Some HR violations in political endeavours through SM misuse include using SM platforms to target political opponents by sharing fabricated information, videos, and pictures that disrespect or expose their privacy. The current findings are consistent with previous studies (Harris & Harrigan, 2015; Safiullah et al., 2017; Stieglitz & Dang-Xuan, 2013) on how expressed SM platforms were utilized to aid the political marketing of politicians. However, these studies differ from our current study

regarding what our investigation discovered – improper SM use. Instead of helping promote courteous and ethical talks and discussions, it was exploited to incite animosity and strife among political opponents. As such, SM needs to help political parties distribute their manifestos, increasing their chances of winning elections. However, the experience in most global southern nations is that they fail to ensure the responsible use of SM among African youth, which promotes HR violations (Ephraim, 2013).

Conclusion and recommendations

The present study examined undergraduate students' perception of youth use of SM in promoting HR violations in Tanzania. The study found that youth had a relatively high degree of understanding and perception of SM and HRs. Youth's higher educational level and regular use of SM while exchanging information and knowledge sharing were among the key factors that explain such broad understanding and awareness of the concepts. Social media has been shown to foster positive youth interactions, promote learning, and improve health and socio-economic development. However, the findings indicated that while using SM, some youth showed inadequate respect for and protection of youth, women and children's rights. Key motivating factors for influencing youths to use SM in connection to human rights violations included a personal desire to make quick and easy money, political influence, peer pressure and partner relationship conflicts, all of which are in line with the Social Aspect Theory that guided this study. The theory assumes that social acts in online social networks are influenced by anticipation of certain benefits, among other factors. The study adds to the existing body of knowledge by uncovering factors influencing youth in universities in the global south to misuse SM, which promotes HRs violation.

Based on the study findings, several relevant recommendations to improve SM use for HR protection are provided. First, efforts should be made at the family and community levels where youth are raised and nurtured to educate and guide the cohort to respect other people's rights by practising better societal values at an earlier stage of their development. As such, educating young people earlier to become responsible and value other people is critical for their positive self-growth and becoming responsible citizens at national and global levels. Second, legal guidance about the use and limitations of SM should be provided by community and youth development officers, as well as various other government officials at the district, wards, and local levels. These are important stakeholders who work closely with youth, assisting them in various socio-economic development initiatives. They should, therefore, mobilize and promote the proper use of ICT facilities on the part of youth to prevent and eliminate SM misuse. A few limitations from the present study that can be addressed in future include exploring the experiences of the youth outside educational institutions who might have relatively diverse experiences and motives to use SM and undertaking a quantitative study with a relatively larger sample size whose findings can be generalized to a larger population. These can add value to the general picture of youth perception of SM use in promoting HR violations in global south countries such as Tanzania.

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